

High absolutive in Mandarin existential-appearing sentences

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Roadmap

1. Existential-appearing sentences
2. Ergative and Absolutive cases
3. Indefiniteness constraint and some exceptions

Existential-appearing sentences

(1.a) existential

这 里 有 人

zhe li you ren

here be person

“There is somebody here.”

(1.b) dis/appearing

王冕 死 了 父 亲

wangmian si le fu qin

NAME die asp. Father

“Wangmian’s father died.”

(1.c) VS order

(我) 来 了 客 人

(wo) lai le ke ren

(1SG) come asp. guest

“Some guest(s) came.”/ “I’ve had some guest(s) coming.”

(1.d) and ...?

跑步机 跑 了 三 个 人

paobuji pao le san ge

treadmill run asp. three class. person

“On this treadmill, three persons ran.”

components

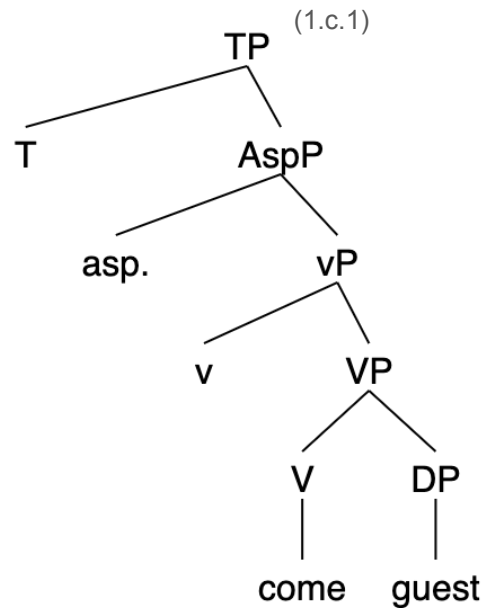
(Pre)	Verb	Post
here	be	(cl.) person
NAME	die asp.	(cl.) father
1SG	come asp.	(cl.) guest
3SG	rot asp.	* $\emptyset$ /cl. apple

Indefiniteness constraint:
non-relational post requires cl.

Hypothesis:

Pre is an argument that receives theta from V.

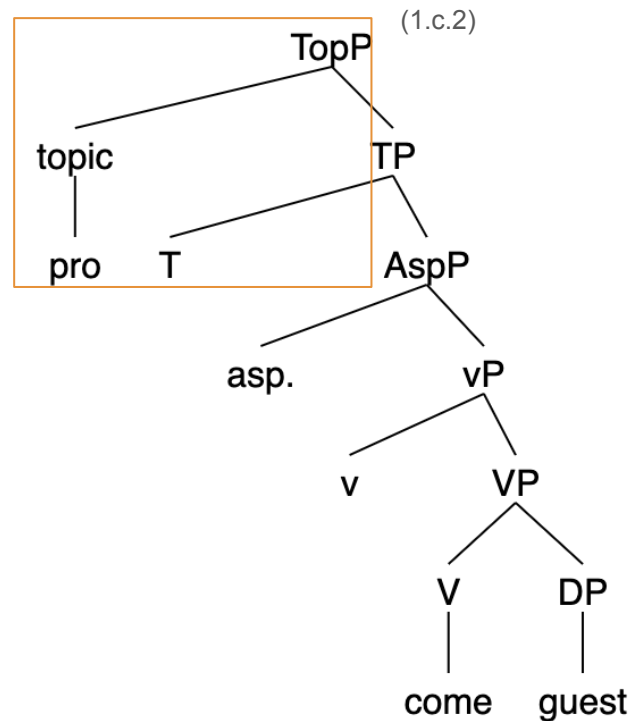
The unaccusative account



(1.c)

(我) 来 了 客人
 (wo) lai le ke ren
 (1SG) come asp. guest

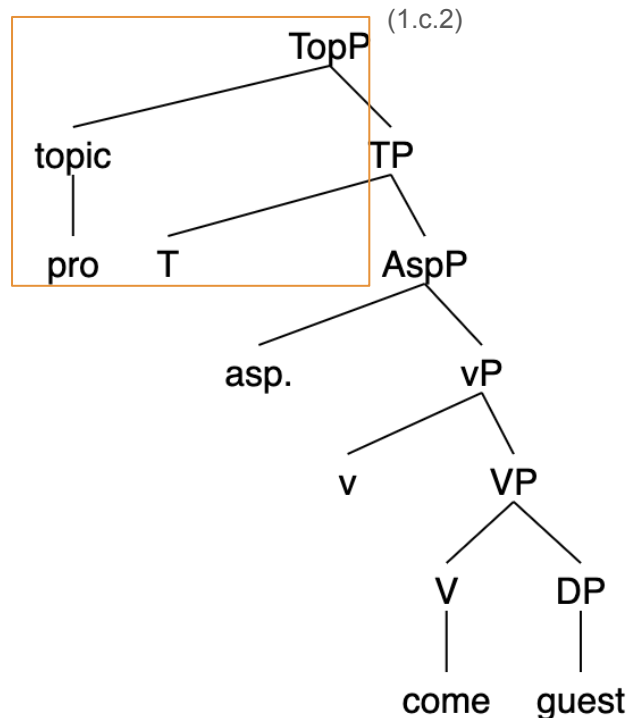
“Some guest(s) came.” / “I’ve had some guest(s) coming.”

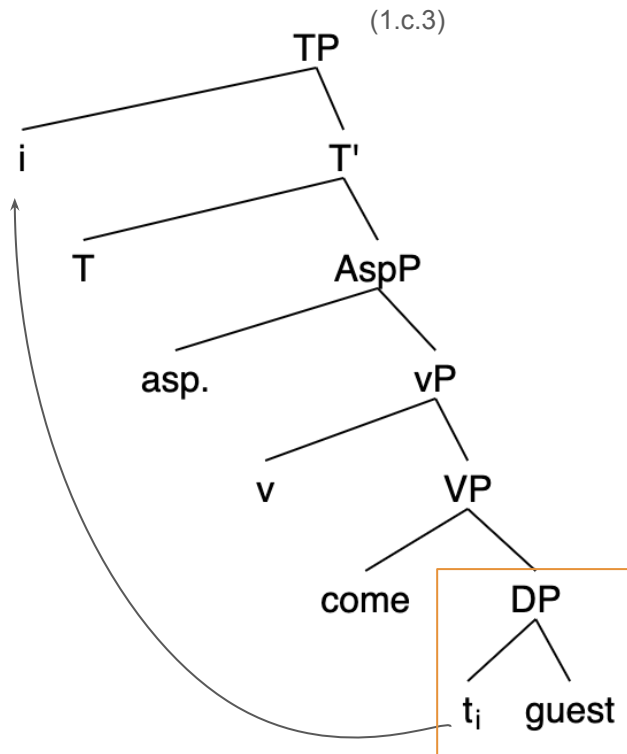


Debates on the Preverbal noun

(1) **dangling-topic + surface-unaccusative** (Pan & Han, 2008)

- **Pre** is base-generated high on the left as a **dangling topic**.
- **Post** is the sole argument of **V**, merged low as the verb's internal argument.
- No possessor raising is involved.
- The postverbal NP remains low because Mandarin allows a kind of **surface unaccusativity**.
- Challenge:
 - misses the strong possessor/affectedness dependency
 - does not naturally explain the construction's lexical restrictions.



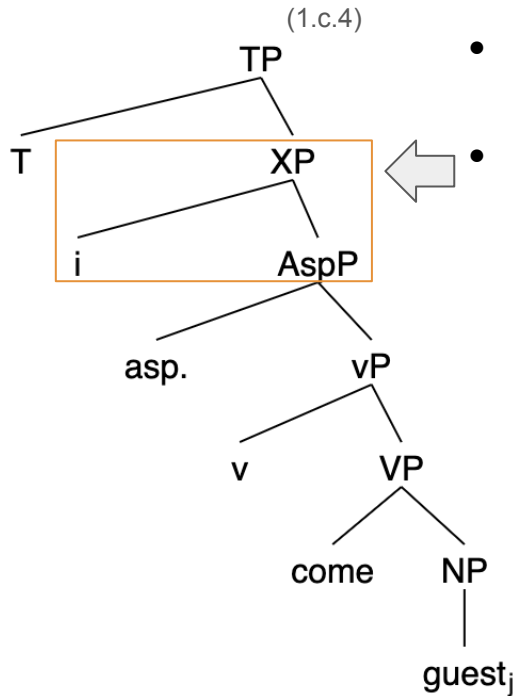


(2) possessor-raising / multiple-nominative A-movement

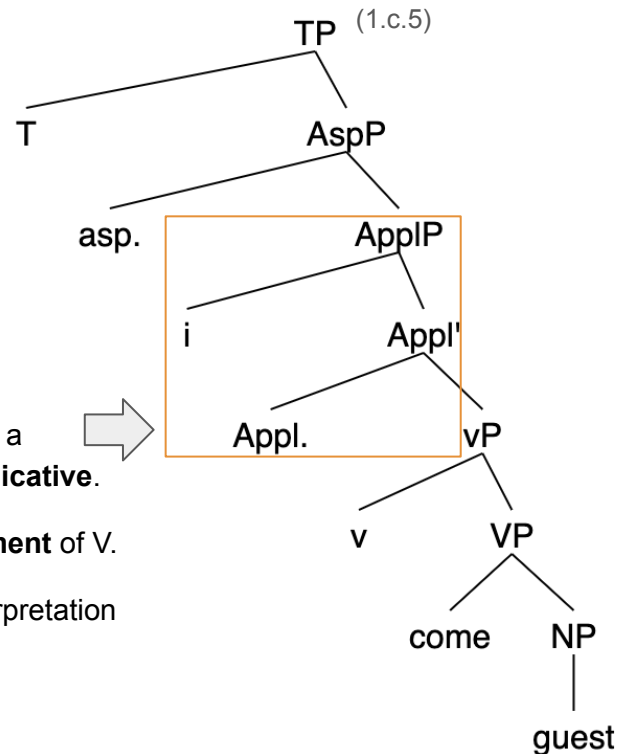
(Hsu & Ting, 2006)

- The source structure contains a possessive DP
- **Pre** starts inside that DP as the **possessor**.
- **Pre raises** into the higher subject position, yielding a multiple-nominative surface structure.
- Challenge:
 - must justify extraction of the possessor out of DP.
 - raises standard issues like the **Left Branch Condition** and the restricted availability of possessor extraction in Mandarin.

(3) **non-movement external-possession analysis**, either in a **binding/extra-argument** (Hole, 2004) form or **applicative-head** form (Yang, 2018).



- **Pre** is merged directly on the clausal spine as an **extra argument**.
- extra arguments **bind thematic variables** instead of being derived by possessor raising.



- **Pre** is introduced syntactically by a functional head, often a **low applicative**.
- **Post** remains the **internal argument** of V.
- The possessor/affectedness interpretation comes from the semantics of the applicative head

Pre is not a PP

(2.1)

又 在 家 里 来 了 客 人

you zai jia li lai le ke ren

again [at home in] come asp. guest

“At home, some guests have come again.”

(2.1)

在 家 里 又 来 了 客 人

zai jia li you lai le ke ren

[at home in] again come asp. guest

“At home, some guests have come again.”

又 (*again*) can sit before or after the PP

(2.3)

教 授 又 来 了 客 人

jiao shou you lai le ke ren

professor again come asp. guest

“The professor has some guests coming again.”

(*2.4)

又 教 授 来 了 客 人

you jiao shou lai le ke ren

again professor come asp. guest

(*2.5)

又 家 里 来 了 客 人

you jia li lai le ke ren

again home in come asp. guest

又 (*again*) cannot sit before Pre. Similar to the subject of an agent-patient transitive:

(2.6)

(*又) 教 授 又 打 了 客 人

(*you) jiao shou you da le ke ren

again professor again beat asp. guest

“The professor hit his guests again.”

Pre can be relativized

(3.1)

___ 来 了 客 人 的 教 授

___ lai le ke ren de jiao shou

___ come asp. guest DE professor

“The professor who has some guests coming”

(3.2)

教 授 来 了 ___ 的 客 人 (在 书 房)

jiao shou lai le ___ de ke ren (zai shufang)

professor come asp. ___ DE guest (at study)

“The guest who has come to the professor’s (are at his study).”

3.2 alone is not very informative since *professor* could also be reconstructed as the modifier of the complex NP under *guest*

Selection asymmetry

(4.1) 客 人 来 了 __ 又 不 说 话

ke ren lai le __ you bu shuo hua

guest come asp. __ conj. NEG speak

“The guest has come but PRO wouldn’t talk.”

(4.2) 来 了 客 人 __ 又 不 说 话

lai le ke ren __ you bu shuo hua

come asp. guest __ conj. NEG speak

“PRO has some guest visiting but wouldn’t talk.”

Roadmap

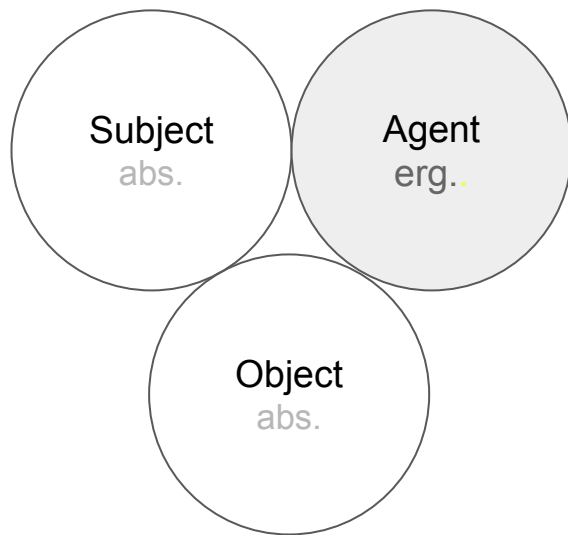
1. Existential-appearing sentences
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Hypothesis:

Pre occupies the same position as a high absoluteive.

Standard typology of case alignment

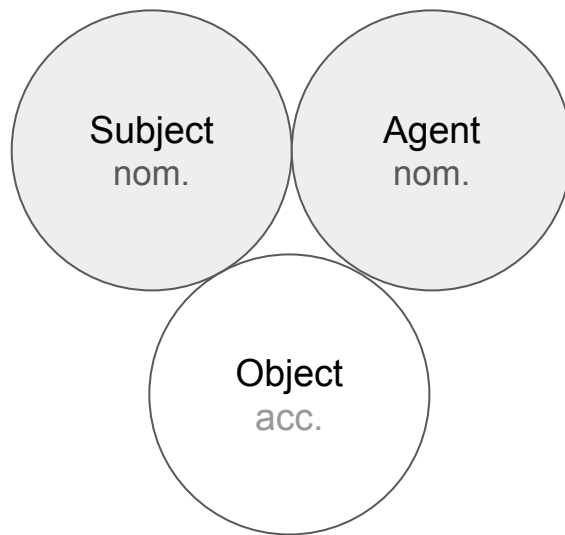
Ergative-Absolutive



transitive: I hit him.

intransitive: Me slept.

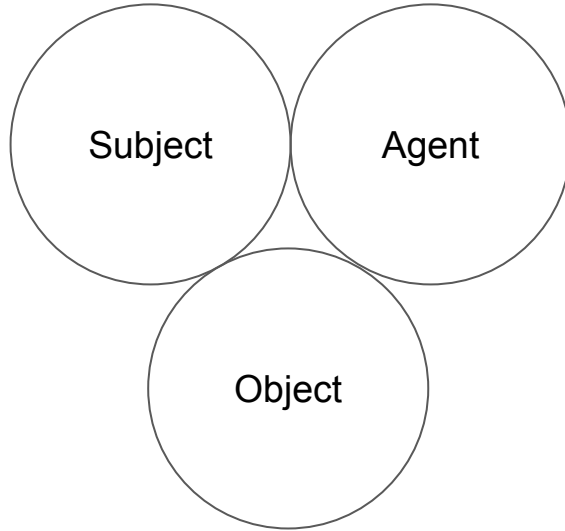
Nominative-Accusative



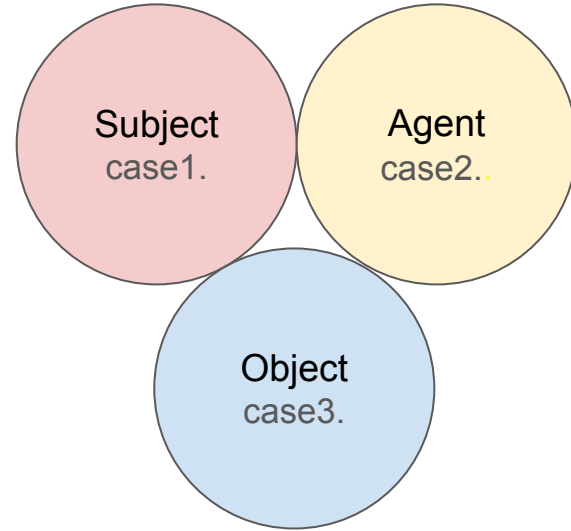
I hit him.

I slept.

Neutral

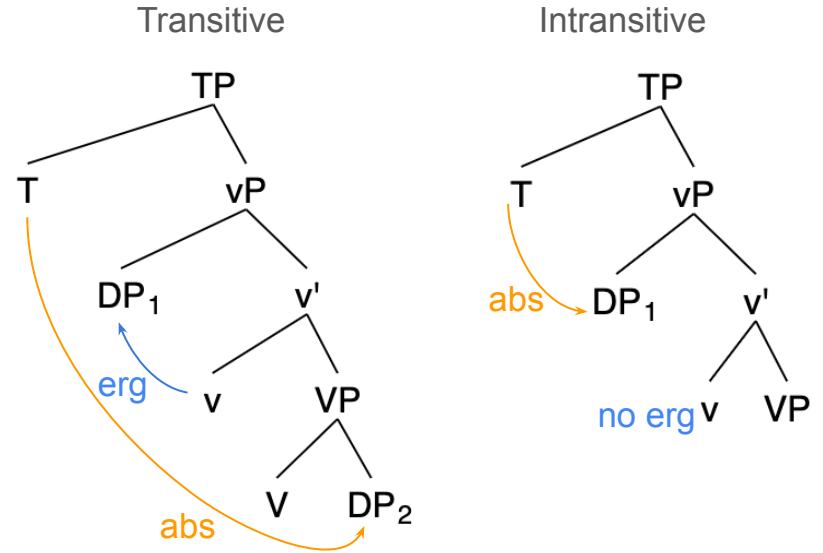


Tripartite



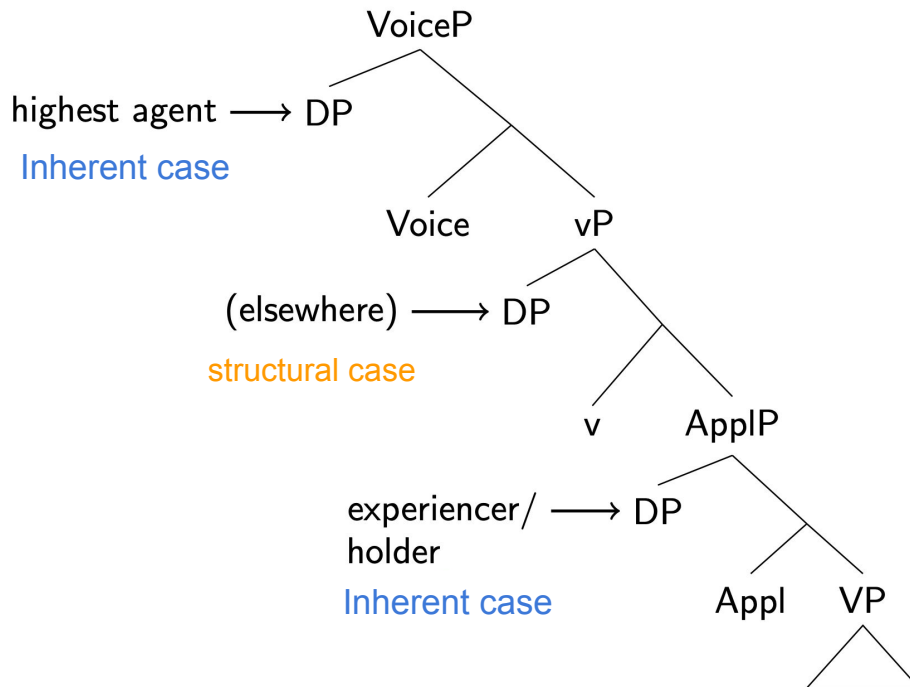
No morphological case in Mandarin,
so usually assumed to be neutral

- Ergative is an inherent case
 - inherently associated with certain theta-roles
 - external arguments
 - assigned by a functional head, such as v
- UTAH violated



Expanded hierarchy

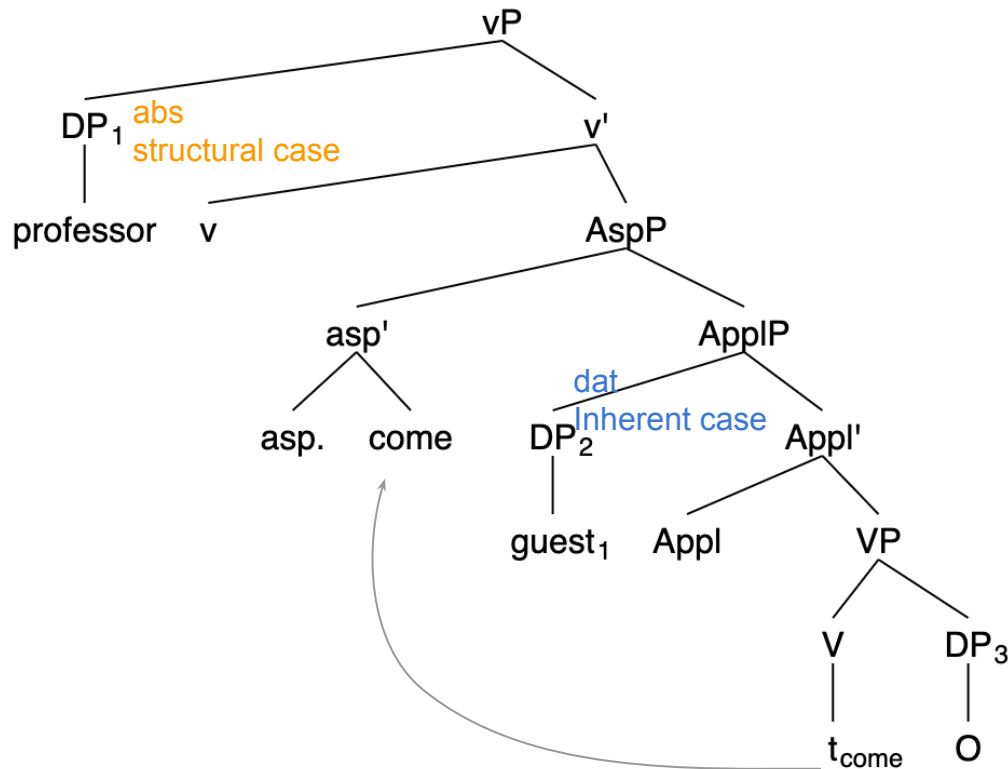
- ABS = elsewhere case
- instead of v, Voice assigns ergative (high agent)
- low agent (absolutive) is introduced by v



(Ershova 2025; Woolford 2006; Wood and Marantz 2015; inter alia)

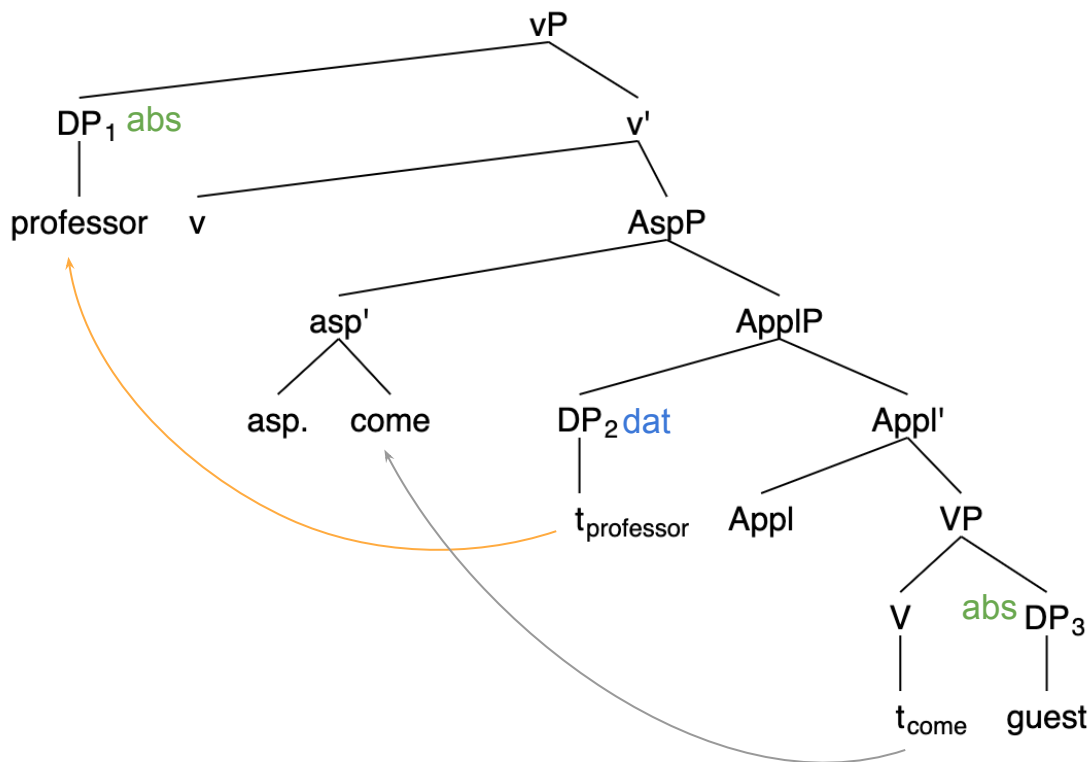
Proposed analysis 1

- Pre is introduced at vP Spec
- Post is introduced at Appl Spec

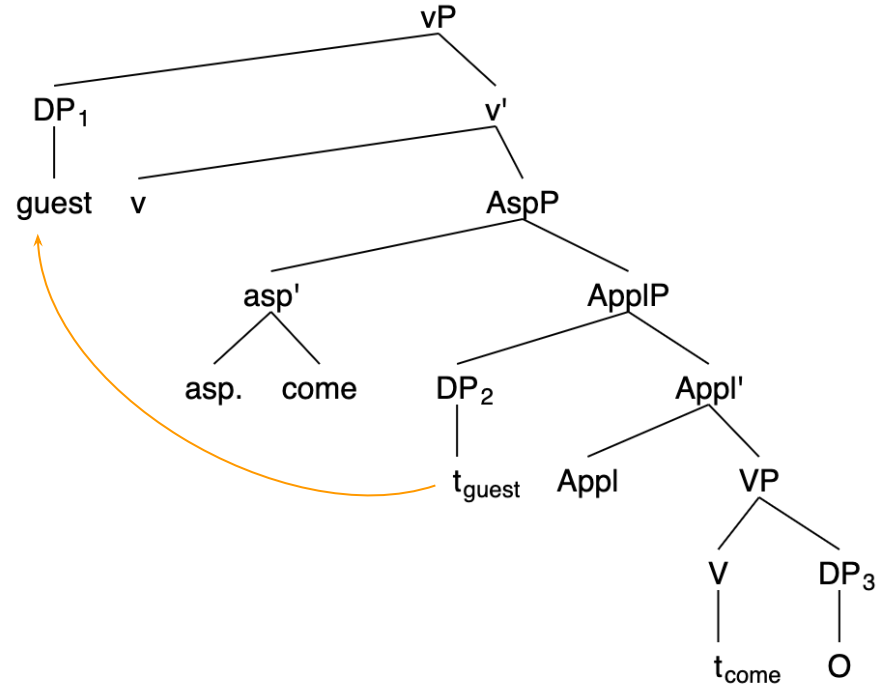
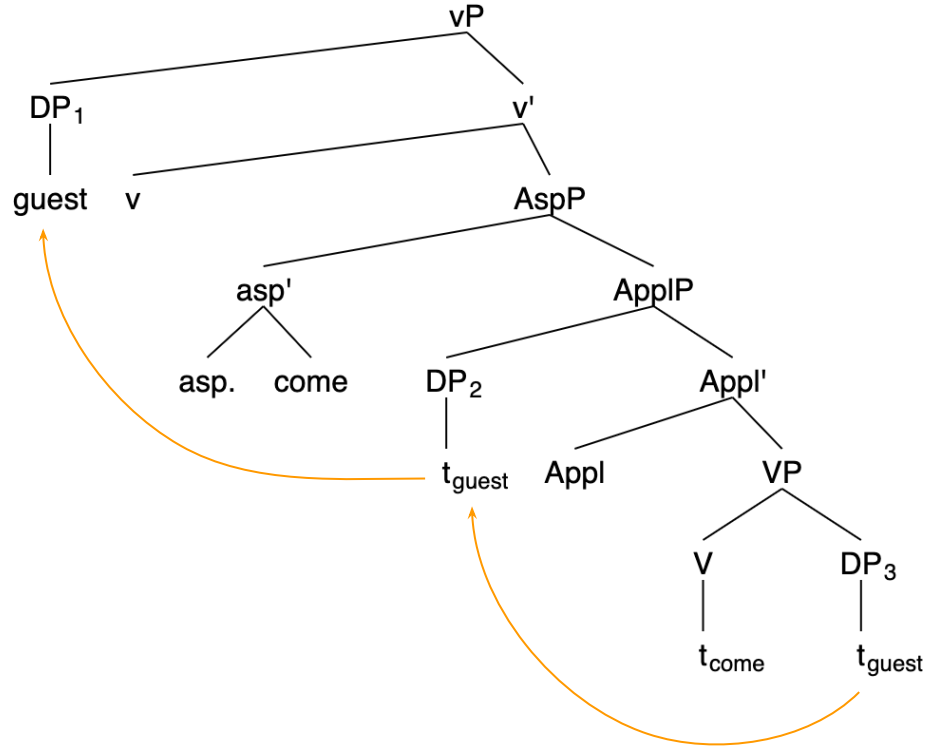


Proposed analysis 2

- Pre is introduced at Appl Spec
- Pre moves to vP Spec
- Post is VP internal



Intransitive



Inner Aspect: participates in the internal composition of the event itself (MacDonald 2008; inter alia)

(*5.1) 王冕 死 父亲 了

Wangmian die father asp.

“Wangmian’s father died.”

(5.2) 王冕 来 客人 了 /??∅

Wangmian come guest asp. /??∅

“Wangmian has some guest(s) over.”

(5.3) 王冕 死 亲戚 了

Wangmian die relative asp.

“Some relative of Wangmian’s died.”

(5.4) 王冕 有 客人 了 /∅

Wangmian come guest asp. /∅

“Wangmian has some guest(s) over.”

Comparison with Tibetan

nga-la ri snang

1SG-dat mountain appear

“To me a mountain appears. I see a mountain.”

Sa-la rtswa skyes

ground-dat grass grow

“Grass grows on the ground.”

nga-la pha shi

1SG-dat father die

“Father died on me./ My father died.”

Cases of our Interest	Common marker(s), Wylie	Core function
Absolutive	zero	Subject of intransitives and object/patient of transitives
Agentive / ergative / instrumental	-s, -gis, -kyis, -gyis, -yis	Agent of many transitive clauses; also instrument/cause
Genitive	-gi, -kyi, -gyi, -yi, -'i	Possession, relation, nominal modification
Dative	-la	Recipient, goal, indirect object, experiencer, sometimes location
Locative	-na	Location, temporal setting, condition/context

Roadmap

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(*6.1) 来 了 他

lai le ta

come asp. 3SG

pronouns cannot occupy Post

(?6.2) 来 了 船

lai le chuan

come asp. boat

some bare nouns are odd in Post

(6.3) 来 了 条 船

lai le tiao chuan

come asp. cl. boat

nouns with classifier is always felicitous

Post's definiteness conditions volitionality

with cl. → unintentional

- (6.1) 渔夫 沉 了 条 船
yu fu chen le tiao chuan
fisherman sink asp. cl. boat
“The fisherman’s boat sank (by accident).”

no cl. → ambiguous

- (6.2) 渔夫 沉 了 船
yu fu chen le chuan
fisherman sink asp. boat
“The fisherman sank (their) boat (intentionally or unintentionally).”

with possessive modifier
→ intentional

- (6.3) 渔夫 沉 了 他 / 老张 的 船
yu fu chen le ta / lao Zhang de chuan
fisherman sink asp. [3SG / Old Zhang DE boat]
“The fisherman caused their/Old Zhang’s boat to sink.”

Transitivized pseudo-transitive in Indonesian

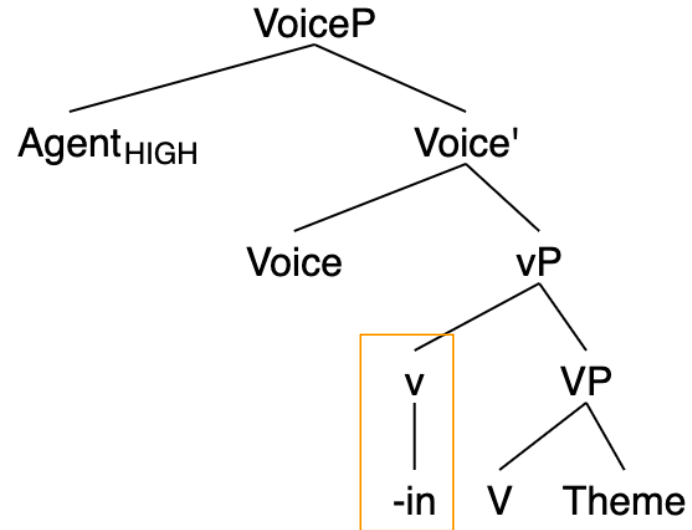
Aku dapat-in buku ini kemarin

I receive-in book this yesterday

“I procured this book yesterday.”

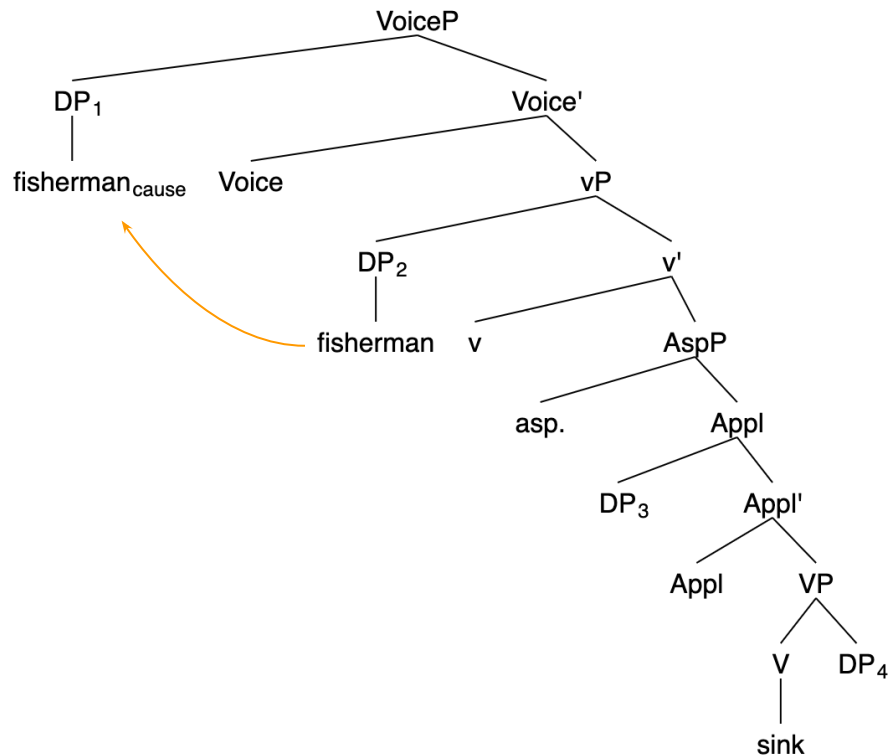
“I received this book yesterday.”

(Ershova 2025)



Transitivized existential-appearing?

- Not every existential-appearing construction can be transitivized
 - 渔夫把船沉了
“The fisherman sank (their) boat.”
 - 我把孩子生了
“I gave birth the child.”
 - *我把人死了
“I killed a person”
 - *我把客人来了
“I invited guest(s)”



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